A majority of the population of such conflict-prone areas tends to be that of silent spectators or fence-sitters. They keenly observe the actions and the results of the encounters between the security forces and the insurgents, and invariably lean towards the winning side. Hence, the overall strategy and ground-level tactics must ensure that we succeed always. When we don't, we must analyse our actions and draw lessons from the mistakes that resulted in our failure. We have to outwit the terrorists and keep them on the run. We ought to think better and fight smarter, that is, plan to be two steps ahead of them, so that they are the ones who are reacting to our moves and strategy and we retain the initiative, and not the other way around.

Experience is a great teacher. We learnt the hard way and became wiser after many years of mountain- and jungle-bashing; and many unsuccessful attempts to carry out vague, pointless and impractical orders from higher HQs, mostly without accurate information, such as 'comb the forest', 'flush out the terrorists', 'carry out area domination', 'seek and destroy', and 'wipe out terrorism'! These are clichés quite commonly bandied about, which make one realize that unless the core philosophy and the fundamental principles of counterterrorism are focused upon and addressed, little can be achieved. Besides, one ought to have precise and actionable intelligence on the terrorists and their supporters, in order to get meaningful results. This is an imperative that is unexceptionable. But I have experienced that this is a major area of weakness while conducting operations. Accurate intelligence is generally hard to come by. Our intelligence agencies need to be strengthened and must be on the ball always, to meet this challenge.

The government's public information set-ups should expose the game plan of the terrorists, their false propaganda, and their utter contempt for human rights, so that the people do not fall prey to their machinations. We must highlight the incidents of rape, torture, killing of innocents, extortion and other atrocities carried out by the terrorists, so that we drive a wedge between the masses and them. We must also seek some accountability from the human rights watchdogs, as quite often they conveniently look the other way on transgressions by the terrorists. It is demoralizing for the security